

3.1.2 Paper 2: Shaping the nation

This paper helps students understand the history of Britain and key events, people and developments which have shaped the nation. This paper covers the requirement to study a minimum of 40% British history. Students will have the opportunity to see how ideas and events in the wider world have affected Britain and shaped the course of the nation's history, but the focus of the paper is British.

Section A: Thematic studies

There are three thematic studies to choose from.

All three give students a coherent understanding of change and continuity across a long sweep of history and each cover all three specified eras. Although each option has a distinct focus, they all illuminate social, political and economic change and the part played by various factors in shaping the history of Britain.

The assessment will enable students to develop their ability to apply second order concepts such as similarity, difference, change, continuity and significance to their knowledge and understanding of key features and characteristics of the period. There will also be an opportunity for them to demonstrate their ability to analyse and evaluate critically and constructively contemporary source material.

Section B: British depth studies

There are four British depth studies to choose from.

The depth studies are either from the Medieval or Early Modern era. They focus on a particular time and people from that time who shaped the nation. Students will build a coherent understanding of the complexity of society and the interplay of different aspects within it.

The historic environment is embedded within the depth studies. This approach promotes coherent understanding of the relationship between the historic environment and the historical events and developments contained in the depth study. Students will be able to make connections and evaluate how specified sites have shaped or have been shaped by the historical events and developments of the time. The historic environment to be studied is identified by AQA (as detailed in [Paper 2: Shaping the nation](#) (page 38)).

The assessment will give students the opportunity to demonstrate their ability to apply second order concepts such as causation, change and consequence to their knowledge and understanding. Students will also analyse and evaluate interpretations to make their own historical claims.